

Practice Paper 12 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — Change in the narrator since starting

1 mark for identifying that the narrator has become more **careful / precise / disciplined** in her baking.

1 mark for showing the **contrast** — earlier she was **casual or sloppy** (“careless pinch”), but she now **measures accurately** by weight, signalling growth as a professional.

Sample answer: The phrase shows that the narrator has **progressed** from a **casual, inexact beginner** into a more **careful and disciplined apprentice** who values accuracy in her work.

Q2. [2] — “Cooling rack of my imagination”

1 mark — She has already **pictured the loaves as a finished success** in her head before they are even baked.

1 mark — This shows she is **hopeful, ambitious, and perhaps overconfident** — already imagining praise and approval rather than concentrating on the task.

Q3. [2] — Two distractions

1 mark each for any two of:

- The delivery van arrived with three unexpected trays of rye flour.
- The driver wanted to chat / kept her talking.
- Somebody else’s phone was ringing inside the kitchen.
- The front bell rang twice, then three times.

Q4. [2] — “A small cold drop somewhere behind my breastbone”

1 mark — Identifies that the narrator is feeling a **sudden flash of dread / sinking fear**.

1 mark — Explains the **physical** nature of the image: the fear is felt **bodily** (a “cold drop”), suggesting how **sharp and instinctive** her panic is when she realises the time has passed.

Q5. [2] — “Weeping a dark, bitter syrup”

1 mark — **Personification**: the loaves are given the human action of **weeping**, as though they are wounded or grieving.

1 mark — Effect: this makes the failure feel **more dramatic and pitiful**, almost as if the loaves themselves are suffering; “bitter” doubles as taste and emotion, underlining her **regret**.

Q6. [2] — Heavier shame; thought of leaving

(a) [1]: A test only affects the narrator herself, but ruining the loaves **lets down other people** — Mr Halim, the regulars, the team who were depending on her work.

(b) [1]: It shows that she is **overwhelmed** — she wants to **escape / give up entirely**, suggesting she feels she cannot face the consequences of her mistake.

Q7. [3] — Mr Halim’s delay before looking at her

1 mark — Suggests Mr Halim is **deliberately controlling his reaction** — pausing to think before he speaks rather than reacting in anger.

1 mark — Suggests he is **calm, measured, and professional**: he assesses the damage first and the apprentice second.

1 mark — Effect on the narrator: the delay **increases her dread** — she is forced to wait in suspense, expecting the worst, which makes his eventual gentleness all the more striking.

Q8. [2] — Timer as “friend”

1 mark — Identifies **personification** — a mechanical object is described as if it were a human companion.

1 mark — Effect: it suggests the timer is **reliable, loyal, and honest** (“never lies”); Mr Halim is **gently teaching** the narrator that the timer must be trusted absolutely, in a warm rather than harsh manner.

Q9. [2] — Impression of Mr Halim as a teacher

1 mark — A clear impression — e.g. **patient, practical, firm but kind, unflappable, generous-spirited**.

1 mark — A supporting detail from Paragraph 6, e.g.:

- He does not shout — he speaks “in the same level voice”.
- He immediately gives her a constructive plan (“You will need to weigh out another twelve... I will help you shape them”).
- He offers a memorable lesson rather than a punishment (“the timer is the only friend a baker has who never lies”).
- He addresses her affectionately as “my dear” even after the mistake.

Q10. [1] — Tapping the watch

1 mark — Any one of: he is silently reminding her of the lesson he just taught her about the timer; he is showing **trust** in her by not repeating it aloud; the small, wordless gesture treats her as a fellow professional, not a child to be scolded.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **hopeful, reflective, quietly resolute, determined, tentatively optimistic.** (Reject: **triumphant, sad, bitter** — these miss the quiet, beginning-again quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “Almost defiantly inefficient”

1 mark — Understanding of **inefficient**: the library does not run by modern economic logic — it gives away its services for free, asks nothing from its users, and is not designed to make a profit.

1 mark — Understanding of **defiantly**: the library seems to **refuse to conform** to a society that values speed, profit and pay-per-use; it **stands against** prevailing values rather than apologising for them.

Q13. [2] — Other users of the library

1 mark each for any two of:

- Job-seekers updating CVs on free computers.
- Retirees attending a Mandarin (language) class.
- New parents bringing babies to a singing session.
- Teenagers studying / revising who cannot study at home.

Q14. [2] — “A universal third place”

1 mark — **Universal**: it is open to **everyone**, regardless of age, income, or purpose.

1 mark — **Third place**: it is **not home** and **not work**, but a **separate public space** where a person can simply spend time on their own terms.

Q15. [2] — What information alone cannot supply

1 mark each for any two of (in own words):

- **Guidance** — personal help in choosing what to read or do.
- **Trust** — a reliable source rather than an unfiltered flood of material.
- **Equipment** (computers / internet access) and **space / time** — somewhere quiet to concentrate.
- **Human judgement** — a librarian who can narrow down ten thousand articles to the two that matter.

Reject answers that simply lift “guidance, trust, equipment, space, and time” without rephrasing.

Q16. [1] — Italics on “for”

1 mark — The italics show **emphasis**: they stress the **purpose** of the library, signalling that the writer is asking a **fundamental, redefining question** — not what a library **is**, but what it **exists to do** in the modern age.

Q17. [2] — “Fashionable, in policy circles”

1 mark — He means that **policy-makers and officials** often **assume** (because it suits them or because it is currently popular) that everyone is already online and digitally confident.

1 mark — **Attitude**: he is **sceptical / mildly critical / disapproving** — he believes the assumption is **complacent and out of touch** with the lives of poorer households.

Q18. [2] — Essential tasks done at the library

1 mark each for any two of:

- Booking a doctor’s appointment.
- Applying for housing / filling in a rent application.
- Renewing a prescription.
- Accepting a school place.

Q19. [2] — “The arithmetic of council budgets is unforgiving”

1 mark — **Arithmetic** reduces decisions about a public service to **cold numbers on a spreadsheet**, stripping out the human stories behind them.

1 mark — **Unforgiving** suggests the system shows **no mercy or flexibility** — once the figures point downwards, the library is judged as failing, regardless of how many people actually use it.

Q20. [2] — “Shifting a cost”

1 mark — Closing a library does not **remove** the need it filled — people still need a place to fill in forms, study, or access the internet.

1 mark — The cost is **transferred** onto the **poorest households**, who must now pay privately for what was once free, or simply go without it — so the savings are an illusion.

Q21. [1] — “Busy, well-connected, often online”

1 mark — Any one of: he is describing the **typical reader** of this article — someone who does not **personally need** the library and may therefore **forget** it matters; the three words **contrast** with the disadvantaged users described earlier; it is a quiet **appeal to conscience**, reminding the comfortable reader of their responsibility to defend the service for others.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.

Modern roles of libraries (Paragraphs 2–4):

1. They serve as a **free workspace and computer hub** for job-seekers and others without good equipment at home.
2. They host **classes, activities and groups** — language lessons, baby singing sessions, study spaces for teenagers.
3. They act as a **universal “third place”** — a free, neutral public space open to all, neither home nor workplace.
4. They offer **human guidance and trusted advice** (e.g. a librarian helping a user filter information) that the internet alone cannot give.
5. They **bridge the digital divide**, helping adults without home internet to complete essential tasks (medical appointments, housing, schooling).

Pressures that threaten libraries (Paragraphs 5–6):

6. **Shrinking budgets and large-scale closures** — e.g. more than 800 libraries closed in England since 2010.
7. **Reliance on unpaid volunteers** and pressure from **rising rents** and shifting council priorities.

8. Spreadsheets **measure only book loans**, not the wider community value, so libraries look like a service in decline even when they are busier than ever — and closing them quietly **transfers costs** onto the poorest users.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Public libraries today serve their communities in many ways, but they also face severe pressures. They provide free computers, study space and group activities for job-seekers, retirees, parents and teenagers, acting as a neutral public space open to all. Librarians offer personal guidance the internet cannot, and the buildings bridge the digital divide for poorer households. However, budgets are shrinking, hundreds of branches have closed, rents are rising, and council spreadsheets ignore the human value that disappears with each closure.

Length count: 78 words from “Public” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —